

Session 8: The Rebellion of the Sons of *Elohim*

Key Takeaways

- The idiomatic phrase “sons of ... ” or “daughters of ... ” is used to indicate members of a group. So the sons of *Elohim* are members of a group of spiritual beings.
- The Bible claims there are powers and rulers in the heavenly realm with agency who are at work in ways very difficult for humans to be aware of.
- The rebellion of the sons of *Elohim* in Genesis 6:1-4 mirrors, inverts, and intensifies the rebellion of the humans in the garden in Genesis 3.

The Rebellion of the Sons of *Elohim*: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 6:1-4

The Rebellion of the Sons of Elohim

- a ¹ And it came about, when humanity began to multiply (רב) on the face of the land ,
b and daughters were born to/for them ,
b' ² the sons of Elohim saw the daughters of humanity that they were good
c and they took wives for themselves, whomever they chose.

- ³ and Yahweh said ,
a “My Spirit/breath will not dwell with humanity forever,
b because he also is flesh;
a' and his days will be one hundred and twenty years.”

- a ⁴ The Nephilim were in the land in those days,
and also afterward,
b when the sons of Elohim went
c into the daughters of humanity
c' and they bore children
b' to/for them ;
a' these are the mighty warriors who are from ancient time, men of the name.

Many modern readers struggle to understand what's happening in this story or its connection to the overall story in Genesis 1-11. This struggle is a sign of our distance from the shared cultural knowledge that is assumed by the biblical authors.

The biblical authors presuppose a whole body of understanding that is clear to someone who (1) has already internalized the entire Hebrew Bible and (2) has a basic knowledge of Mesopotamian history and Babylonian propaganda. It's difficult for modern readers to track because we don't share that ancient context.

Let's tackle this text with a series of questions that will illuminate the key issues.

Who Are the Sons of *Elohim*?

The phrase "sons of *Elohim*" (בני אלהים) is used five times in the Hebrew Bible, and it always refers to spiritual beings who inhabit the divine realm in God's presence, otherwise known as the divine council.

Job 1:6 (also 2:1) NASB*

Now there was a day when **the sons of God** came to present themselves before the LORD, and the one opposed [= the Satan] also came among them.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Job 38:4, 7 NASB

⁴ Where were you when I laid the foundation of the earth? ...

⁷ When the morning stars sang together, and all **the sons of God** shouted for joy?

There are two variant phrases found in Psalm 29:1, Psalm 89:7, and Psalm 82:6.

Psalm 29:1-2 NASB*

¹ Ascribe to the LORD, O **sons of God** [= **sons of El**], ascribe to the LORD glory and strength.

² Ascribe to the LORD the glory due to his name; worship the LORD in holy array.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 89:5-8 NASB*

⁵ The heavens will praise your wonders, Yahweh; your faithfulness also in the assembly of **the holy ones**.

⁶ For **who in the skies** is comparable to the LORD? Who among **the sons of God** [= **sons of El**] is like Yahweh,

⁷ an **El** greatly feared in **the council of the holy ones**, and awesome above all **those who surround him**?

⁸ Yahweh, **Elohim of hosts**, who is like you, O mighty Yahweh?

Psalm 82:1, 6-7 NASB*

¹ God has taken his place in **the divine council**;
in the midst of the *elohim* he holds judgment. ...

⁶ I said, "You are *elohim*,
sons of the Most High, all of you;

⁷ nevertheless, like humans you shall die,
and fall like any prince."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

This group of spiritual beings called "the divine council" (Ps. 82:1, 89:7) is also called "the host of heaven" (1 Kgs. 22:19) or "holy ones" (Ps. 89:5, 7; Job 5:1; Zech. 14:5; Dan. 8:24). These members of the divine council are the inhabitants of the spiritual realm. They are images of God's glory in the heavenly realm and correspond with humans in the earthly realm.

The Meaning of "Sons of ____" or "Daughters of ____"

In Hebrew, the plural phrase "sons of ____" is a figure of speech that means "members of the class/group of ____." The bold word is used as a descriptor of a class.

"Sons of **Bethlehem**" = inhabitants of Bethlehem (Ezra 2:21)

"Daughters of **the city**" = female residents of a city (Lam. 3:51)

"Daughters of **Edom**" = inhabitants of Edom (Ezek. 16:57)

"Sons of **Egypt**" = inhabitants of Egypt (Ezek. 16:26)

"Sons of **the prophets**" = members of Elisha's prophetic group (2 Kgs. 2:15)

"Sons of **humanity**" = members of the human race (2 Sam. 7:14)

"Daughters of **the song**" = female singers (Ecc. 12:4)

In each case, the plural "sons/daughters of ____" refers to people who are members of a group or class that qualifies their identity in some way. In Genesis 6:1-2 we find:

- "Daughters of humanity" = human daughters
- "Sons of *Elohim*" = *Elohim* beings, i.e., spiritual beings

Genesis 6:1 draws a strong contrast between the "daughters of humanity" and the "sons of *Elohim*" because the point at issue is the violation of boundaries between human and divine.

Other Interpretations of the Sons of *Elohim*

Some interpreters argue that the sons of *Elohim* in Genesis 6 are human beings.

The Sethite View

This view is a Christian interpretation that dates back to the 4th century C.E. It argues that the sons of God are the godly line of Seth, who worship the true God ([Gen. 4:26](#)) and are contrasted with the un-godly line of Cain. Genesis 5:1-5 portrays Adam as a “son of God,” and so it is argued that the sons of God are in fact the sons of Adam through Seth. For more on this, see Augustine’s *City of God*, book 4, chapter 23.

Problems: The Hebrew Bible attests the plural phrase “sons of *Elohim*” and its variations over eight times, and it is used specifically to refer to the divine council. The text is more likely contrasting a boundary violation between humans and *elohim*. Seth and Cain are not mentioned in Genesis 6:1-4, nor is there any reference to intermarriage prohibitions between two human families.

The Divinized Human Rulers View

This modern view appeals to texts where human rulers are put on analogy with the divine. For example, when someone from the line of David is adopted as a “son of *Elohim*” (see [Ps. 2:7](#)), or when God’s covenant people Israel are called Yahweh’s “firstborn son” ([Exod. 4:23](#)). In this view, Genesis 6:1-4 is about human rulers who abused their divinely appointed role and engaged in polygamous marriages. For more information, see Meredith Kline, “Divine Kingship and Genesis 6:1-4.”

Problems: Genesis 6:1-2 nowhere says that the marriages were polygamous. And while there are ancient Near Eastern parallels to divine kings as the son of a god, there is no parallel to an entire group or nation that is called “God’s son” like Israel is ([Exod. 4:23](#)). The plural phrase “sons of *Elohim*” in biblical Hebrew refers uniquely to spiritual beings.

Conclusion: The most compelling explanation of the words used in Genesis 6:14 is that spiritual beings have abandoned the heavenly realm and invaded the human realm.

Reflection Question

Who or what are the sons of *Elohim*?